

# Workstation Troubleshooting Guide

Tier 1/2 field guide for Windows endpoint issues

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## Universal First Steps (Every Ticket)

- 1 Reproduce or screenshot the exact error; note when it started and what changed (updates, new software, moves).
- 2 Check RMM: pending reboot? disk space <10%? failing SMART? runaway process? recent patch?
- 3 One clean reboot (not shutdown with Fast Startup — use Restart) before deep-diving intermittent issues.
- 4 Scope it: one user, one machine, or many? Many = check server/network/service health first, not the endpoint.

## Performance Issues

| Symptom               | Diagnosis                                                                                           | Resolution                                                                        |
|-----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Slow always           | Task Manager: disk at 100%? RAM pressure? HDD not SSD?                                              | SSD upgrade if HDD; RAM if consistently >85%; remove startup bloat; malware scan  |
| Slow after login      | Startup apps, mapped-drive timeouts, profile size, GPO processing                                   | Disable heavy startup items; fix dead drive mappings; profile cleanup             |
| Random freezes        | Event Viewer critical errors (Kernel-Power 41 = power/hardware), disk errors (Event 7/153), thermal | Reseat/replace hardware per evidence; update firmware/drivers; check PSU/thermals |
| Browser-only slowness | Extensions, cache, GPU acceleration conflicts                                                       | Fresh profile test isolates it; remove extensions; clear cache                    |

## Boot & OS Issues

| Symptom                           | Resolution Path                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| No boot / BSOD loop               | Note the stop code → boot to WinRE → startup repair → System Restore point → 'sfc /scannow' + 'DISM /Online /Cleanup-Image /RestoreHealth' from recovery → last resort in-place repair install. Pull data first via recovery environment if disk health is suspect. |
| BitLocker recovery prompt         | Retrieve key from Entra/vault; investigate cause (firmware update, TPM change, board swap) before suspending protection for planned maintenance                                                                                                                     |
| Update failures                   | Free 15GB+, run built-in troubleshooter, clear SoftwareDistribution, retry; repeated same-KB failure → targeted research, don't loop forever                                                                                                                        |
| Profile won't load (temp profile) | Registry ProfileList repair (rename .bak SID) or new profile + data migration; check disk errors as root cause                                                                                                                                                      |

## Peripherals & Common Quick Wins

- No audio: check output device selection first (docks steal default), then driver, then hardware.
- Second monitor blank: cable/port swap test isolates 80% of cases; then dock firmware and display driver.
- USB device flaky on dock: power budget — try direct port; update dock firmware.
- Wrong time/date breaking auth or TLS: fix time service and CMOS battery — cause of mysterious 'certificate invalid' errors.

Time-box: Tier 1 escalates any workstation issue exceeding 45 minutes without a clear path. Reimaging a managed, backed-up workstation is often faster than a 3-hour ghost hunt — check data protection status first (BVT-IRP-051), then decide.